Fix My Code

One copy-and-paste prompt that finds the bug in your code, fixes it, and explains the mistake in simple words - so the same error does not stop you again.

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Free student notes - Coding & Computer set

What this note is: a single shortcut, on its own, so you can save it, print it and use it in seconds. Copy the prompt on page 2 into ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Muse or any other AI chat, paste your broken code and the error message under it, and get a working fix with the reason explained.

The copy-and-paste prompt

Fix My Code **Works in: ChatGPT - Claude - Gemini - Muse**

> My code is not working. Help me fix it like a patient coding teacher.
>
> Language: [LANGUAGE, for example Python, HTML, JavaScript]
> What my code should do: [ONE LINE - what you wanted it to do]
> The error message I get: [PASTE THE FULL ERROR, or write "no error - it just gives the wrong result"]
>
> My code:
> [PASTE YOUR CODE HERE]
>
> Reply in this order:
> 1. THE FIX - show the corrected code, with the changed lines clearly marked.
> 2. WHAT WAS WRONG - explain my mistake in simple words, in 3 lines or less. Name the exact line.
> 3. WHY IT HAPPENED - one short paragraph a beginner can understand.
> 4. HOW TO AVOID IT - one practical tip so I do not make this mistake again.
> 5. ONE TEST - give me one input I can run to check the fix really works, and the result I should see.
>
> Keep my code style and variable names. Do not rewrite the whole program in a new way unless my way cannot work - if so, tell me why first.

Fill the brackets: the error message is the most important part. Copy every word of it, including the line number - that is what tells the AI exactly where the bug is hiding.

Before you paste: a 30-second check

- **Copy the whole error.** Not just the last line, and never a photo of the screen - paste the text so nothing is missed.
- **Paste the whole file or function,** not only the line that looks wrong. The real cause is often a few lines above.
- **Say what should happen.** "It should print the total marks" helps far more than "it is broken".
- **Remove passwords and keys** from code before pasting it anywhere. Never share login details with any AI chat.

How a fix session runs

1. **Run your code and copy the error.** Note the exact line number the error names.
2. **Paste the prompt, your code and the error** into any AI chat and send it.
3. **Read "What was wrong" first** - before you touch the fixed code. Understanding comes before copying.
4. **Change only the marked lines** in your own file. Small, careful changes keep the rest of your work safe.
5. **Run the test the AI gave you.** If the result matches, the fix is real. If a new error appears, paste that new error back into the same chat and repeat.

Worked example: a Python marks program

A student writes a program to add 10 bonus marks to a score - and it crashes.

```
marks = input("Enter marks: ")
total = marks + 10
print("Total:", total)
```

The error: `TypeError: can only concatenate str (not "int") to str`

AI - The fix: Change line 1 to: `marks = int(input("Enter marks: "))`

AI - What was wrong: Line 1. `input()` always gives text (a string), even when you type a number. On line 2 you tried to add the number 10 to text, and Python cannot add text and numbers together.

AI - How to avoid it: Whenever a number comes from `input()`, wrap it at once: `int(...)` for whole numbers, `float(...)` for decimals.

AI - One test: Run it and type 40. You should see: Total: 50.

> **The lesson that stays:** most beginner errors are small - a missing bracket, text treated as a number, one wrong indent. The prompt works because it forces the AI to name the line and the reason, not just hand you new code.

Follow-up lines you can add

- "Explain the fixed line word by word - I am a beginner."
- "Do not change anything else. Show me only the lines I must edit."
- "Give me a tiny practice question on this same mistake so I can test myself."

Short versions for common jobs

Job	Short prompt
Error message only	"Explain this error in simple words and tell me the 2 most likely causes: [PASTE ERROR]"
No error, wrong result	"This code runs but gives the wrong answer. Expected: [RESULT]. Got: [RESULT]. Find where the logic goes wrong: [CODE]"
Web page not showing right	"My HTML/CSS page looks wrong: [DESCRIBE WHAT YOU SEE]. Here is my code: [CODE]. Find the mistake and show only the corrected lines."
Code works, but I do not understand it	"Explain this code line by line in simple English, like a teacher: [CODE]"
Make it cleaner	"This code works. Make it shorter and easier to read without changing what it does, and explain each improvement: [CODE]"

Use it honestly - and safely.

Fixing your own practice code with AI help is good learning. Copying an AI fix into an exam, test or graded assignment without understanding it is cheating - and it fails you the moment you face a question alone. Always run the test, always read the explanation, and never paste passwords, API keys or anyone else's private code into a chat.

Final checklist

- Full error message pasted as text, with its line number.
- Whole code pasted - and one line saying what it should do.
- "What was wrong" read and understood before copying the fix.
- Only the marked lines changed in my own file.
- The AI's test run by me, with the expected result seen.
- I can explain the mistake in my own words - that is the real fix.

> **Remember:** a fixed program you do not understand will break again. A mistake you understand becomes a skill you keep.